

## Living layers

A tropical rain forest is like a tall building that has several different floors. Scientists call these “strata” or layers.

## Emergents

Only the tallest trees, called “emergents,” stick out of the highest layer.

---

## Canopy

Usually between 65–130ft (20–40m) above ground, the canopy is hot and fairly dry. Most animals live here.

---

## Understory

Shaded by the canopy, but still well above ground, this is the realm of ferns, vines, and smaller animals.

---

## Shrub layer

Since this layer is very dark, shorter plants and young trees compete to get the most sunlight.

---

## Forest floor

The hottest, darkest, and dampest layer, the forest floor is covered with dead leaves and is alive with insects.

